

# *The Cask of Amontillado*

Edgar Allan Poe · 1846

First published: Godey's Lady's Book, Nov 1846

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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# Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

**Edition:** Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Cask_of_Amontillado (revision 14833566), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

**Grades:** Grades 8–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

## Essential questions

- What does The Cask of Amontillado suggest about revenge and pride?
- What does The Cask of Amontillado suggest about deception?
- What does The Cask of Amontillado suggest about the burden of the past?

## Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

## Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

**Primary codes:** RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
**Assessments:** Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
**Differentiation:** Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
**Materials:** Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

## The 90-minute lesson

| # | Segment | Mode | Minutes | Clock |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bell-ringer | You do | 8 | 0–8 |
| 2 | Vocabulary with etymology notes | I do | 10 | 8–18 |
| 3 | Background and context | I do | 10 | 18–28 |
| 4 | I do: modeled close reading | I do | 12 | 28–40 |
| 5 | We do: guided annotation | We do | 15 | 40–55 |
| 6 | You do: independent annotation | You do | 15 | 55–70 |
| 7 | Discussion | We do | 10 | 70–80 |
| 8 | Exit ticket / chapter quiz | You do | 7 | 80–87 |
| 9 | Closure | I do | 3 | 87–90 |
| | **Total** | | **90** | |

# Syllabus

| Week | Chapters | Lessons | Focus and activities | Assessment |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | The Cask of Amontillado | 1 × 90 min (90 min) | *revenge and pride*<br>• Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure<br>• Story quizzes in the app<br>• Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week) | Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt |

# Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

# Lesson 1: The Cask of Amontillado

**Focus:** revenge carried out with perfect control

**Content note (a man is walled up alive):** Sensitive content: A man is walled up alive. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
**Student preview:** Heads-up: this story includes a man is walled up alive.
**Suggested language:** "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Montresor, vowing revenge for 'a thousand injuries' and an insult from Fortunato, lures the drunken wine connoisseur during carnival into his family catacombs with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado. Deep in the vaults he chains Fortunato into a niche and walls him in alive. He tells the story fifty years later; no one has disturbed the bones.

**Background:** The story (1846) is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city. Its catacombs echo Roman and Parisian ossuaries. Amontillado is a Spanish sherry.

**Significance:** It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR.

*Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)*

**0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
*Settle in and write for five minutes: Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes a man is walled up alive.*

**8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)**
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
*Today's words are trickle, requesting, materially, explicit, luckily. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "The drops of moisture trickle among the bones." In this sentence it means: to flow in drops. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.*

**18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)**
Present the historical and literary background.
*Here is what the first readers of The Cask of Amontillado would have known. The story (1846) is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city. Its catacombs echo Roman and Parisian ossuaries. Amontillado is a Spanish sherry. Why does this story matter? It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR. Write down one question you want answered.*

**28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)**
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
*Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to revenge carried out with perfect control? I circle "impunity", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.*

**40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)**
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
*Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.*

> *The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge. You, who so well know the nature of my soul, will not suppose, however, that I gave utterance to a threat. At length I would be avenged; this was a point definitively settled—but the very definitiveness with which it was resolved, precluded the idea of risk. I must not only punish, but punish with impunity. A wrong is unredressed when retribution overtakes its redresser. It is equally unredressed when the avenger fails to make himself felt as such to him who has done the wrong.*

**55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)**
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
*Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Setting, Characterization: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Cask of Amontillado develops the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.*

**70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)**
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
*Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to revenge and pride? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.*

**80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)**
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
*Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about revenge carried out with perfect control, backed by one short quotation.*

**87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
*Today we saw how irony shapes revenge carried out with perfect control. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.*

Total: 90 minutes.

### *Vocabulary with etymology notes*

| Word | Definition (in this sentence) | In context | Word history |
|---|---|---|---|
| **trickle** (verb) | to flow in drops | *The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **requesting** (verb) | express the need or desire for; ask for | *I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **materially** (adverb) | with respect to material aspects | *In this respect I did not differ from him materially: I was skilful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **explicit** (adjective) | precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication | *I had told them that I should not return until the morning, and had given them explicit orders not to stir from the house.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **luckily** (adverb) | by good fortune | *I said to him—"My dear Fortunato, you are luckily met.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **accosted** (verb) | approached and spoken to | *He accosted me with excessive warmth, for he had been drinking much.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **impunity** (noun) | exemption from punishment or loss | *I must not only punish, but punish with impunity.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **subsided** (verb) | wear off or die down | *When at last the clanking subsided, I resumed the trowel, and finished without interruption the fifth, the sixth, and the seventh tier.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **increases** (verb) | grows | *"The nitre!" I said; "see, it increases.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **depended** (verb) | be contingent upon (something that is elided) | *From one of these depended a short chain, from the other a padlock.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |

### *Discussion questions*

1. Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and pride?

### *Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)*

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

**Literal / recall**

1. What reason does Montresor give for his revenge? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A thousand injuries and then an insult
2. How does Montresor lure Fortunato into the vaults? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado
3. What is Fortunato wearing? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells
4. What is Montresor's family motto about? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: No one attacks me with impunity
5. How long ago did the events take place, as Montresor tells it? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Fifty years
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Cask of Amontillado” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Montresor, vowing revenge for 'a thousand injuries' and an insult from Fortunato, lures the drunken wine connoisseur during carnival into his family catacombs with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado. Deep in the vaults he chains Fortunato into a niche and walls him in alive. He tells the story fifty years later; no one has disturbed the bones.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Cask of Amontillado”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Cask of Amontillado” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.” What does “trickle” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: trickle: to flow in drops.

10. Reread: “I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.” What does “requesting” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: requesting: express the need or desire for; ask for.

**Inferential / analytical**

1. What does “The Cask of Amontillado” suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about revenge carried out with perfect control? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. In the passage that begins “The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge.”, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Cask of Amontillado”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Montresor, vowing revenge for 'a thousand injuries' and an insult from Fortunato, lures the drunken wine connoisseur during carnival into his family catacombs with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado. Deep in the vaults he chains Fortunato into a niche and walls him in alive. He tells the…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Cask of Amontillado” set up that the rest of The Cask of Amontillado will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with revenge and pride? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
10. Background: The story (1846) is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city. Its catacombs echo Roman and Parisian ossuaries. Amontillado is a Spanish sherry. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

**Evaluative / synthesis / creative**

1. A critic might argue: “It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Cask of Amontillado” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about revenge carried out with perfect control? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Cask of Amontillado”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to deception: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “The Cask of Amontillado” treats revenge carried out with perfect control with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Cask of Amontillado see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve revenge and pride? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about revenge carried out with perfect control? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

## *Annotation focus*

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

## *Chapter quiz*

1. What reason does Montresor give for his revenge?

   A. A thousand injuries and then an insult

B. A stolen inheritance

C. A broken engagement

D. A lost duel

2. How does Montresor lure Fortunato into the vaults?

A. With a map to buried gold

B. By challenging him to a duel

C. By asking for medical help

D. With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado

3. What is Fortunato wearing?

A. A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells

B. A soldier's uniform

C. A priest's robe

D. A black mask and cloak

4. What is Montresor's family motto about?

A. Mercy is strength

B. Faith above all

C. No one attacks me with impunity

D. Wine reveals truth

5. How long ago did the events take place, as Montresor tells it?

A. One week

B. Ten years

C. A century

D. Fifty years

6. In the line “The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.”, what does “trickle” most nearly mean?

A. express the need or desire for; ask for

B. to flow in drops

C. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication

D. with respect to material aspects

7. In the line “I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.”, what does “requesting” most nearly mean?

A. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication

B. to flow in drops

C. express the need or desire for; ask for

D. with respect to material aspects

**Answer key:** 1. A (A thousand injuries and then an insult); 2. D (With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado); 3. A (A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells); 4. C (No one attacks me with impunity); 5. D (Fifty years); 6. B (to flow in drops); 7. C (express the need or desire for; ask for)

### *Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)*

**Middle School** (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Cask of Amontillado,” how does Poe show revenge carried out with perfect control? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

**HS Freshman** (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Cask of Amontillado, how does Poe develop the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

**HS Sophomore** (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Cask of Amontillado develops the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of revenge carried out with perfect control. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

**HS Senior** (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Cask of Amontillado suggests about revenge carried out with perfect control. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

**AP** (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses irony in The Cask of Amontillado to complicate the reader's understanding of revenge carried out with perfect control. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

**College Freshman** (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Cask of Amontillado within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of revenge carried out with perfect control responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

**College Sophomore** (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Cask of Amontillado alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of revenge carried out with perfect control follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

**College Junior** (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Cask of Amontillado and its treatment of revenge carried out with perfect control. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

**College Senior** (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Cask of Amontillado as evidence for a larger claim about revenge carried out with perfect control in The Cask of Amontillado. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

**Graduate / PhD** (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Cask of Amontillado as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of revenge carried out with perfect control. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Cask of Amontillado.

### *SAT-style questions*

1. *In this respect I did not differ from him materially: I was skilful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “materially” most nearly mean?

   A. wear off or die down

   B. with respect to material aspects

   C. be contingent upon (something that is elided)

   D. grows

2. *The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge. You, who so well know the nature of my soul, will not suppose, however, that I gave utterance to a threat. At length I would be avenged; this was a point definitively settled—but the very definitiveness with which it was resolved, precluded the idea of risk. I must not only punish, but punish with impunity. A wrong is unredressed when retribution overtakes its redresser. It is equally unredressed when the avenger fails to make himself felt as such to him who has done the wrong.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Cask of Amontillado”?

   A. The loss of faith in human goodness

   B. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

   C. A crime that backfires

   D. Revenge carried out with perfect control

**SAT key:** 1. B (with respect to material aspects); 2. D (Revenge carried out with perfect control)

# Whole-book test

**The Cask of Amontillado: whole-book test** · 90 minutes

## Part I: Multiple choice

1. What reason does Montresor give for his revenge?
   A. A thousand injuries and then an insult
   B. A stolen inheritance
   C. A broken engagement
   D. A lost duel
2. How does Montresor lure Fortunato into the vaults?
   A. With a map to buried gold
   B. By challenging him to a duel
   C. By asking for medical help
   D. With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado
3. What is Fortunato wearing?
   A. A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells
   B. A soldier's uniform
   C. A priest's robe
   D. A black mask and cloak
4. What is Montresor's family motto about?
   A. Mercy is strength
   B. Faith above all
   C. No one attacks me with impunity
   D. Wine reveals truth
5. How long ago did the events take place, as Montresor tells it?
   A. One week
   B. Ten years
   C. A century
   D. Fifty years
6. In the line “The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.”, what does “trickle” most nearly mean?
   A. express the need or desire for; ask for
   B. to flow in drops
   C. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
   D. with respect to material aspects

7. In the line “I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.”, what does “requesting” most nearly mean?
   A. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
   B. to flow in drops
   C. express the need or desire for; ask for
   D. with respect to material aspects
8. As used in the story (“The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.”), what does “trickle” mean?
   A. to flow in drops
   B. by good fortune
   C. wear off or die down
   D. express the need or desire for; ask for
9. As used in the story (“I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.”), what does “requesting” mean?
   A. approached and spoken to
   B. express the need or desire for; ask for
   C. grows
   D. with respect to material aspects
10. As used in the story (“In this respect I did not differ from him materially: I was skilful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could.”), what does “materially” mean?
    A. exemption from punishment or loss
    B. be contingent upon (something that is elided)
    C. with respect to material aspects
    D. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
11. As used in the story (“I had told them that I should not return until the morning, and had given them explicit orders not to stir from the house.”), what does “explicit” mean?
    A. wear off or die down
    B. to flow in drops
    C. by good fortune
    D. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
12. As used in the story (“I said to him—"My dear Fortunato, you are luckily met.”), what does “luckily” mean?
    A. by good fortune
    B. grows
    C. express the need or desire for; ask for
    D. approached and spoken to

## Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how revenge and pride develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how deception develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how the burden of the past develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

## Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (revenge and pride, deception, the burden of the past) and argue how the ending reframes it.

## Answer key

**Answer key:** 1. A (A thousand injuries and then an insult); 2. D (With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado); 3. A (A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells); 4. C (No one attacks me with impunity); 5. D (Fifty years); 6. B (to flow in drops); 7. C (express the need or desire for; ask for); 8. A (to flow in drops); 9. B (express the need or desire for; ask for); 10. C (with respect to material aspects); 11. D (precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication); 12. A (by good fortune)

# Essay assignments

## Essay: Revenge and pride

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cask of Amontillado teaches about revenge and pride. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops revenge and pride across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of revenge and pride. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Cask of Amontillado (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of revenge and pride, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cask of Amontillado's treatment of revenge and pride in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: Deception

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cask of Amontillado teaches about deception. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops deception in The Cask of Amontillado. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops deception across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of deception. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of deception in The Cask of Amontillado. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Cask of Amontillado (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of deception, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cask of Amontillado's treatment of deception in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on deception in The Cask of Amontillado that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on deception in The Cask of Amontillado. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about deception in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on deception in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: The burden of the past

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cask of Amontillado teaches about the burden of the past. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the burden of the past across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the burden of the past. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Cask of Amontillado (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the burden of the past, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cask of Amontillado's treatment of the burden of the past in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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